“I’m washing the pans.” Rose shook her head.

“Look at me, Rose.”

Her sister turned and Léa saw something fixed and hard in Rose’s eyes. “What is it? Tell me, I will—”

Thud. The door opened. Léa turned to see Nadiya gripping the doorframe.

“What’s happened?” Léa asked.

Nadiya’s skirt was damp. An image of Maria flashed in Léa’s mind.

“Has your water broken?” Léa called out.

“Yes,” she said. “The baby’s coming.”

Léa turned to Rose. “The baby’s early. Josef won’t be back until tomorrow. Can you assist with the delivery?”

“Of course,” Rose said. “But have you delivered a baby before?”

“I watched Josef deliver Maria—”

“*Ahhhh*, I can’t,” Nadiya cried out. “It hurts.”

“Oh, yes, you can,” Léa said, hurrying to Nadiya. “Rose, wash your hands, then bring her to bed in the back room. I’ll get everything we will need and meet you there.” She stroked Nadiya’s back, gentle and steady. “Don’t worry. You’ll be fine.”

“Promise me something?” Nadiya looked straight at Léa’s eyes.

“What?”

“Don’t leave my baby here.” She winced against the pain. “In case I—”

“You aren’t going anywhere. You and the baby will be fine.”

Nadiya squeezed Léa’s hand. “My child was conceived in love.” She exhaled in quick puffs. “If she’s orphaned—”

“Don’t think like that,” Léa said. “Nothing will happen to you.”

“Take her out of here!” Nadiya’s eyes were misty, and her face shone with sweat. She held Léa’s gaze. “Promise?”

All that mattered was quelling the fear in Nadiya, who had somehow talked herself into a panic. “I promise,” she said, in a soothing tone, directing her to Rose, who had just returned. “She’ll bring you to the back room. I’ll join you shortly.”

“I know I can trust you. You and Josef will care for my child. You’ll keep a promise.”

Rose glanced at Léa, arching her eyebrows as if to ask what promise.

“I’ll tell you later,” she whispered, dismissing Nadiya’s ominous tone.